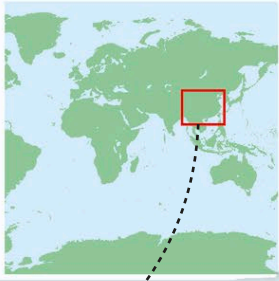
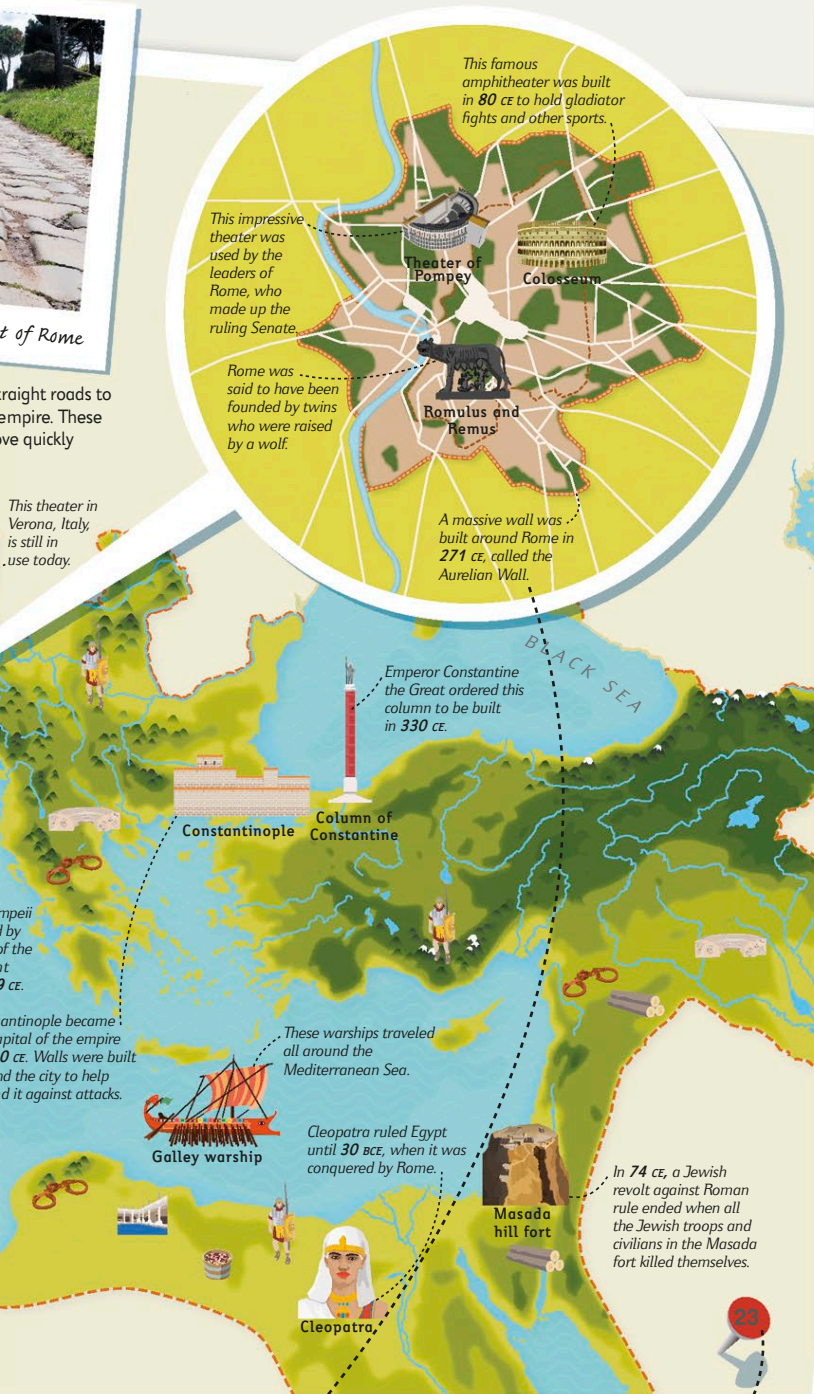


States at war

The five kingdoms each battled to become the most powerful. They were eventually united into the huge empire of China.



These mini-maps show you where an area is in the world.

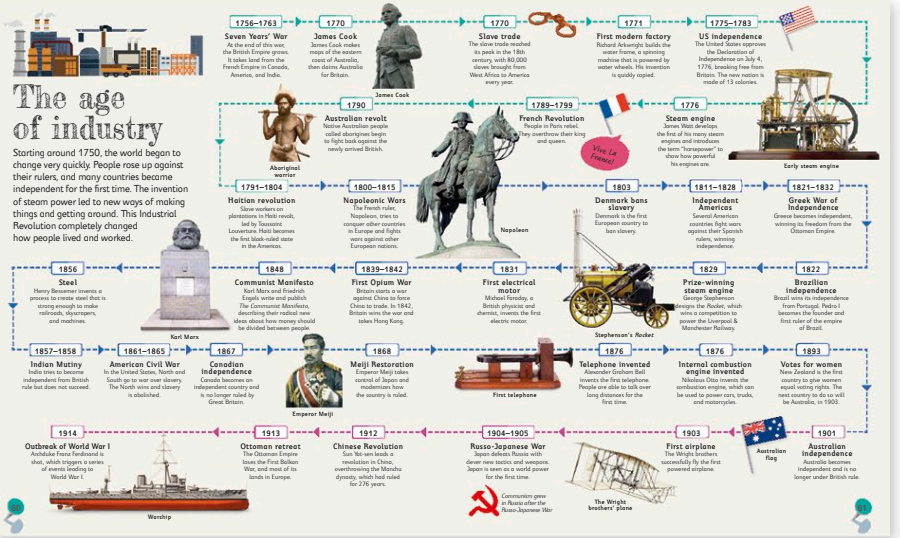


Close-up map

These maps show extra details of interesting areas that would be too small to show on the main maps.

Page numbers

The color of the circle matches the chapter color and tells you which chapter you are in.



Timelines

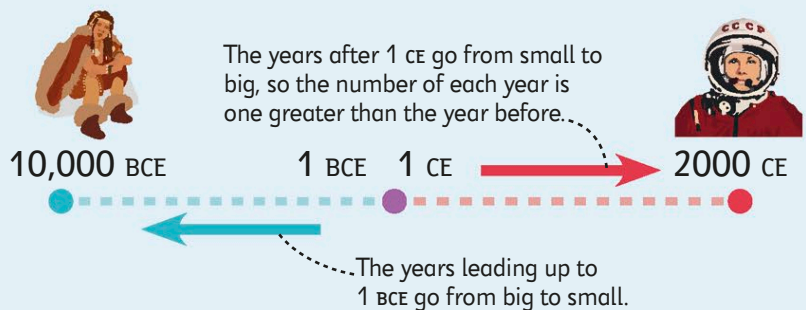
Each chapter starts with a timeline spread. The timelines show you events in different parts of the world in the order that they happened.

How years are numbered

Each year is given a number to help people keep track of what happened (and happens) when. These numbers are called dates. Here are some things that are useful to know about historical dates.

CE and BCE

You will see that some dates have "CE" or "BCE" after them. CE means "Common Era" and BCE means "Before the Common Era." CE is used for dates after the year 1 BCE, and BCE for dates before 1 CE. In this book, if a date doesn't have CE or BCE after it, it is CE.



Centuries

A century is a period of 100 years. Historians often talk about periods of time using centuries, for example, "the 18th century." The years covered by a century are the 100 leading up to it. So the 18th century covers the years 1700–1799. Here are some examples.

Century	Time covered	Century	Time covered
14th century	1300–1399 CE	18th century	1700–1799 CE
15th century	1400–1499 CE	19th century	1800–1899 CE
16th century	1500–1599 CE	20th century	1900–1999 CE
17th century	1600–1699 CE	21st century	2000–2099 CE